

Love in Motion — Route Safety Audit & Draft Daily Splits

Attunga → Sydney Opera House · McGrath Foundation Draft v1 — 11 July 2026. Distances verified against published sources; items marked $\triangle$ still need a route-planner / Street View / on-ground check before locking.

1. Corridor decision (brief: "whatever is safest")

Recommendation: New England Highway corridor south to the Hunter, then the coastal path through Newcastle and the Central Coast, then the Old Pacific Highway into Sydney.

Why not Thunderbolts Way (Walcha–Gloucester): it's quieter for traffic, but the road itself is documented as narrow, poorly maintained, potholed, very hilly and winding with ramps up to 20% north of Gloucester, and not recommended in wet weather — with roughly 150 km between services (Walcha → Gloucester) and known mobile blackspots. For a runner with a support vehicle, blind narrow descents with no shoulder are a worse risk profile than a highway with a sealed shoulder, and the service gap makes crew logistics and emergency response much harder.

Why the New England Hwy wins on safety: sealed shoulders along much of it (confirmed on the TfNSW Cycleway Finder), towns every 12–54 km, hospitals near the route (Quirindi, Scone, Muswellbrook, Singleton, Maitland — $\triangle$ confirm each facility's current status), better mobile coverage, and easy support-vehicle shadowing. The known gaps are specific and fixable (Section 3).

South of the Hunter the choice is forced anyway: **running on the M1 is prohibited**, so the legal route diverts via Newcastle, the Fernleigh Track, the Central Coast lakes and the Old Pacific Highway — which happens to also be the safest and most scenic stretch, with dense shared-path coverage.

2. The distance is bigger than the campaign number

Verified leg-by-leg, the legal, safe route totals **~480–490 km Attunga → Opera House** (midpoint $\approx$ 484 km) — not ~415 km. The published 395–410 km Tamworth–Sydney figures assume the M1, which can't be run. Worth deciding early whether the campaign copy moves to "almost 500 km" (a stronger story anyway) or keeps "over 415 km" as a safe floor.

3. Draft daily splits (varied 40–50 km, town-anchored)

13 running days. Short days are deliberate: launch day, one mid-expedition recovery day, and the finish day.

Day	Leg	Km	Road data (Cycleway Finder)	Flags
1	Attunga → Tamworth	20	Fossickers Way unmapped	Launch day. Quieter back-road option: Appleby Lane / Gidley–Appleby Rd — council-designated "share the road" cycling routes with edge lines. ⚠ verify surface
2	Tamworth → Wallabadah	54	Mostly unclassified , intermittent shoulder	⚠ Longest day. Biggest verify zone on the whole route — Street View pass essential; support vehicle shadowing all day
3	Wallabadah → Murrurundi	37.5	Short shoulder fragments; gaps near Willow Tree & Ardglen	⚠ Purple/unclassified sections around the climb to the Gap
4	Murrurundi → Scone	40	Shoulder with general-road	Murrurundi Gap climb first up; ⚠

Day	Leg	Km	Road data (Cycleway Finder)	Flags
			gaps through the pass	mark exact gap chainages
5	Scone → Muswellbrook	26	Largely shoulder; short town sections	Recovery day. Scone & Muswellbrook hospitals ⚠ confirm
6	Muswellbrook → Singleton	47	Patchy — shoulder with unclassified stretches	⚠ Coal-traffic corridor; verify gaps + plan crew points
7	Singleton → Maitland (via Branxton)	49	Good shoulder; shared paths near Huntlee/Branxton	⚠ Ensure routing stays on old New England Hwy, not Hunter Expressway (excluded)
8	Maitland → Newcastle	35	Dense urban network	Route via shared paths; pick line through Thornton/Hexham carefully ⚠ (Hexham bridge pinch point)
9	Newcastle → Budgewoi	50	Fernleigh Track (15 km off-road) + coastal paths	Best-protected long day on the route
10	Budgewoi → Gosford	38	Coastal shared-path network	The Entrance waterfront; ⚠ confirm 23 km Entrance→Gosford leg (single source)

Day	Leg	Km	Road data (Cycleway Finder)	Flags
11	Gosford → Mooney Mooney	28	Old Pacific Hwy mapped	Short on purpose — positions the two big Old Pac climbs for fresh legs
12	Mooney Mooney → Hornsby (via Brooklyn)	~35	Old Pac Hwy — popular cycling corridor	⚠️ Brooklyn→Hornsby distance needs route-planner confirm (~25–30 km); Pie in the Sky / Cowan climbs
13	Hornsby → Sydney Opera House	~25	Dense metro network	Finish day; harbour crossing via Sydney Harbour Bridge walkway

Total ≈ 484 km (legs individually source-verified; ⚠️ legs 6, 9-anchor distances Scone→Aberdeen, Singleton→Branxton, Belmont→Swansea, Swansea→Budgewoi, The Entrance→Gosford, Brooklyn→Hornsby need a route-planner confirm before locking).

4. Shoulder-gap summary (from the TfNSW Cycleway Finder pass)

- **Well covered (orange shoulder / paths):** Scone→Muswellbrook, Singleton→Branxton→Maitland, everything from Newcastle south.
- **Patchy (verify each gap):** Willow Tree→Murrurundi→Scone (pass country), Muswellbrook→Singleton.
- **No data at all (treat as unverified, not unsafe):** Attunga→Tamworth (Fossickers Way), most of Tamworth→Wallabadah→Willow Tree.
- The **Cycling Excluded** layer must be checked when locking the Hunter Expressway bypass (Day 7) and the Hawkesbury crossing (Day 12).

5. Next actions

1. Street View pass over Days 2–4 and 6 to chainage-mark every shoulder gap (I can do this next).
2. Route-planner confirm of the six $\triangle$ leg distances, then lock splits.
3. Decide campaign distance wording (~484 km vs "over 415 km").
4. Per-day safety sheets: hospitals, police, SES, water, toilets, reception blackspots — all to be verified live, not assumed.
5. Crew meeting points + accommodation per finish town.

Sources

- TfNSW Cycleway Finder (coverage pass, 11 Jul 2026):
<https://maps.transport.nsw.gov.au/egeomaps/cycleway-finder/index.html>
- Tamworth Regional Council Rural Cycling Routes Safety Upgrade:
<https://haveyoursay.tamworth.nsw.gov.au/rural-cycling-routes-safety-upgrade>
- Thunderbolts Way conditions:
<https://www.dangerousroads.org/australia-and-oceania/australia/5915-thunderbolts-way.html>
- Leg distances: Wikipedia town pages (Attunga, Wallabadah, Murrurundi, Scone, Aberdeen, Singleton, Maitland, Belmont, Swansea, Budgewoi, The Entrance, Brooklyn, Hornsby), Wikivoyage Willow Tree, Aussie Towns (Wallabadah, Murrurundi, Swansea, Brooklyn), City of Newcastle (Fernleigh Track), NSW Coast Cycle Trail (Gosford–Brooklyn), Tamworth Region tourism (Tamworth–Sydney ~400 km).